490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 22 OF 26

# Resurrection and Ascension

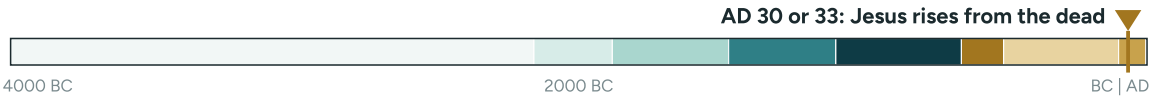
*Mark 16; Luke 24; John 20–21; 1 Corinthians 15; Acts 1*



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 22




## Introduction: Sunday Morning

Lesson 21 ended at a sealed tomb. Imagine the Saturday that followed. The disciples were most likely hiding behind locked doors. Their teacher was dead. Every hope they had placed in him, that he was the Christ, the King, the one who would redeem Israel, seemed to lie in that tomb with him. Two of them would later say it in four sad words: "But we had hoped" (Luke 24:21; Lesson 1).

Then came Sunday. This lesson tells what happened on the first day of the week, the forty days that followed, and the day Jesus was taken up into heaven. The resurrection is not a happy ending tacked onto the story. Paul says it is "of first importance" (1 Cor. 15:3), and that if it did not happen, Christianity is false. Everything stands or falls here.

## The Word: Resurrection

> **John 11:25–26** *"Jesus said to her, 'I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live, and everyone who lives and believes in me shall never die. Do you believe this?'"*

**ἀνάστασις** *(anastasis, "resurrection")*

*literally "a standing up again"*

| **ἀνά (ana)** | + | **ἵστημι (histēmi)** |
|---|---|---|
| *"up, again"* | | *"to stand"* |
| Upward, once more. | | To rise to your feet. |

**Payoff:** Resurrection is a dead body standing up again, alive. It is more than a soul living on, and more than a ghost or a vision. For Jesus it meant a body transformed and never to die, and he promises the same to everyone who belongs to him. Notice what he said to Martha: "I *am* the resurrection."

## Part One: The Empty Tomb

Early on Sunday morning, a group of women who had watched Jesus die came to the tomb with spices to anoint his body. On the way they worried about who would roll away the heavy stone. When they arrived, it was already rolled back, and the body was gone. An angel said to them, “Do not be alarmed. You seek Jesus of Nazareth, who was crucified. He has risen; he is not here. See the place where they laid him” (Mark 16:6).

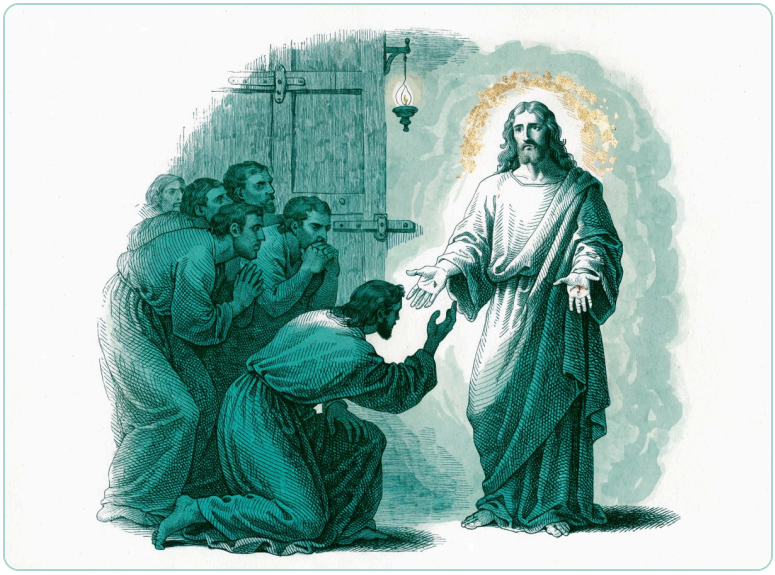
Mary Magdalene stayed behind at the tomb, weeping, sure that someone had taken the body. A man she thought was the gardener asked why she was crying. Then he said one word: “Mary.” She turned and cried, “Rabboni!” which means Teacher (John 20:16). According to John, the first person to see the risen Jesus was a woman whose life he had once rescued from seven demons (Luke 8:2).

That detail matters. In that culture, a woman’s testimony was often not accepted in court. If the disciples had invented the story, women are the last witnesses they would have chosen. The most natural explanation is that the Gospels report it because that is what happened.

## Part Two: He Appeared

That evening the disciples were together behind locked doors, afraid. “Jesus came and stood among them and said to them, ‘Peace be with you.’ When he had said this, he showed them his hands and his side. Then the disciples were glad when they saw the Lord” (John 20:19–20). They thought at first he was a ghost, so he told them to touch him, “For a spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have,” and he ate a piece of broiled fish in front of them (Luke 24:39, 42–43). His body was real, the same body with the nail marks in it, yet changed: no longer able to die.

Thomas was not there that night, and he refused to believe: “Unless I see in his hands the mark of the nails… I will never believe.” A week later Jesus appeared again and said, “Put your finger here, and see my hands; and put out your hand, and place it in my side. Do not disbelieve, but believe.” Thomas answered, “My Lord and my God!” (John 20:25, 27–28). Then Jesus said something for everyone who would come after: “Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed” (20:29). That means you.



*"Put your finger here, and see my hands" (John 20:27).*

Jesus also restored Peter, who had denied him three times. By the Sea of Galilee, three times Jesus asked, "Simon, son of John, do you love me?" And three times he gave him a job: "Feed my lambs," "Tend my sheep," "Feed my sheep" (John 21:15–17). The risen Jesus brings failures back.

Over forty days, Jesus "presented himself alive to them after his suffering by many proofs" (Acts 1:3). Some twenty years later, Paul wrote down a list of witnesses he had received much earlier (1 Cor. 15:3): Peter, the twelve, "more than five hundred brothers at one time, most of whom are still alive," James, all the apostles, and finally Paul himself (1 Cor. 15:5–8). "Most of whom are still alive" amounted to an invitation: go ask them.

### He Appeared: Witnesses to the Risen Jesus

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Sunday morning | Mary Magdalene at the tomb | *John 20:11–18* |
| Sunday morning | The women running from the tomb | *Matt. 28:8–10* |
| Sunday | Peter | *Luke 24:34; 1 Cor. 15:5* |
| Sunday afternoon | Two disciples on the Emmaus road | *Luke 24:13–35* |
| Sunday evening | The disciples behind locked doors | *John 20:19–23* |
| A week later | Thomas, with the others | *John 20:26–29* |
| Later | Seven disciples by the Sea of Galilee | *John 21:1–23* |
| Later | The eleven on a mountain in Galilee | *Matt. 28:16–20* |
| Later | More than five hundred at one time | *1 Cor. 15:6* |
| Later | James, the Lord's brother | *1 Cor. 15:7* |
| Day 40 | The apostles at the ascension | *Acts 1:3–11* |
| Years later | Paul, on the Damascus road | *1 Cor. 15:8; Acts 9* |

*"He presented himself alive to them after his suffering by many proofs" (Acts 1:3).*

Something changed these people. Frightened men hiding behind locked doors became bold witnesses who were beaten and jailed, and several of them were killed, rather than deny what they had seen. Jesus' own brother James, who did not believe in him during his ministry (John 7:5), became a leader of the church in Jerusalem (Gal. 2:9). People do not die for something they know is a lie.

## Part Three: Why It Matters

Paul is blunt: "if Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile and you are still in your sins" (1 Cor. 15:17). The resurrection is God's verdict on the cross. Jesus "was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification" (Rom. 4:25). His death paid the debt in full. His resurrection is God's public verdict that the payment was enough. The Father raised him and declared him righteous, and everyone joined to him by faith alone shares that verdict. That is what Paul means by "raised for our justification." The resurrection also proves he is who he said he is, "declared to be the Son of God in power… by his resurrection from the dead" (Rom. 1:4).

It also means death has been defeated. Jesus came "that through death he might destroy the one who has the power of death, that is, the devil, and deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong slavery" (Heb. 2:14–15). The risen Jesus says, "I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades" (Rev. 1:18).

And his resurrection is the first of many. “But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep” (1 Cor. 15:20). The firstfruits were the first sheaf of the harvest, the promise that the rest was coming. One day every believer’s body will be raised like his: “What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable. It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory” (15:42–43). Christians can say at a graveside what no one else can: “O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?” (15:55).

## Part Four: The Ascension

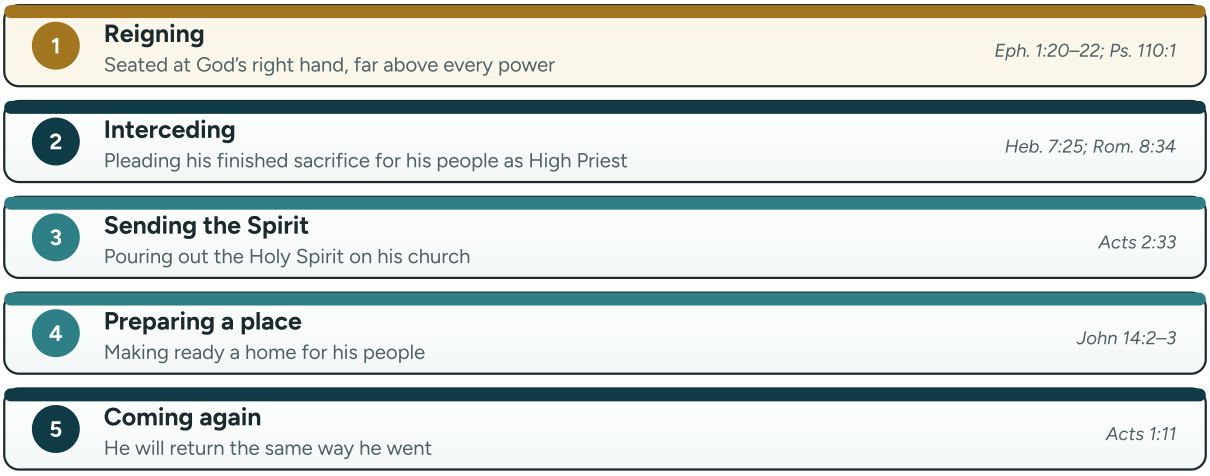
Forty days after Easter, Jesus led his disciples out to the Mount of Olives, near Bethany. He told them to wait in Jerusalem for the Holy Spirit, “and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth” (Acts 1:8). He “led them out as far as Bethany, and lifting up his hands he blessed them. While he blessed them, he parted from them and was carried up into heaven” (Luke 24:50–51). A cloud took him out of their sight, and two angels said, “This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven” (Acts 1:11).



*“While he blessed them, he parted from them and was carried up into heaven” (Luke 24:51).*

Surprisingly, the disciples did not go home sad. “They worshiped him and returned to Jerusalem with great joy” (Luke 24:52). Why joy? Jesus had told them, “it is to your advantage that I go away” (John 16:7). He went up in the same body they had touched, and he reigns now as a real man at God’s right hand. God “raised him from the dead and seated him at his right hand in the heavenly places, far above all rule and authority” (Eph. 1:20–21), just as David foretold: “Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool” (Ps. 110:1). And from there he works for his people now.

### What the Ascended Jesus Is Doing Now




*"And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age" (Matt. 28:20).*

Before he left, Jesus gave his followers their mission: "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age" (Matt. 28:18–20). Lesson 23 will show what happened when the Spirit came and they obeyed.

THREAD WATCH

THE LAMB The Lamb who was slain did not stay dead. In heaven John saw "a Lamb standing, as though it had been slain" (Rev. 5:6). He still bears the marks of his sacrifice, and he is alive and reigning forever.

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE On the night of his resurrection, Jesus "breathed on them and said to them, 'Receive the Holy Spirit'" (John 20:22), echoing God breathing life into Adam (Gen. 2:7). He ascended, yet he promised, "I will come again and will take you to myself, that where I am you may be also" (John 14:3). Until then, "I am with you always."

CORE DOCTRINE 22 OF 26

## The Resurrection and Ascension

Jesus rose bodily from the dead on the third day. He ascended into heaven in that same body and now reigns at the Father's right hand. His resurrection is God's seal on his finished work and the promise that all who belong to him will rise too.

**KEY VERSES**

1 Corinthians 15:3–8, 20; Acts 1:9–11; Romans 4:25; Ephesians 1:20–22

**WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES**

*"The third day he rose again from the dead; He ascended into heaven, And sitteth on the right hand of God the Father Almighty."* (Apostles' Creed)

**WHY IT MATTERS**

Death is not the end for those who trust Christ. Their Lord has already walked out of the grave.

## The Turn: Do You Believe This?

When Jesus told Martha, "I am the resurrection and the life," he did not stop with a statement. He asked her a question: "Do you believe this?" (John 11:26). He asks you the same thing.

If Jesus is still in the tomb, then his promises died with him, and we are still in our sins. But if he rose, then everything he said is true. His death really paid for sin. Death is really defeated. And your future, if you belong to him, is not a grave but a resurrection body and a world made new.

Everyone will be raised one day, "some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt" (Dan. 12:2). God "has fixed a day on which he will judge the world," and he has given proof of it "by raising him from the dead" (Acts 17:31).

Christians grieve when people they love die, but not "as others do who have no hope. For since we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so, through Jesus, God will bring with him those who have fallen asleep" (1 Thess. 4:13–14). Here is the promise: "if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved" (Rom. 10:9). Thomas would not believe without seeing. Jesus calls you blessed if you believe without seeing. Turn from your sin, and trust the living Lord.

### Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read the accounts.** Read Mark 16:1–8, Luke 24, and John 20–21. (Your Bible will note that the oldest manuscripts of Mark end at 16:8.) Notice the different details each witness remembers.

2. **Examine the evidence.** List the reasons this lesson gives for believing the resurrection happened. Which one is strongest to you?

3. **Face death with hope.** Read 1 Corinthians 15:50–58. If you are grieving someone who died in Christ, thank God for the resurrection to come.

4 **Come back like Peter.** If you have failed Jesus, hear his question: "Do you love me?" Tell him, and take up whatever he gives you to do.

5 **Pray to the ascended King.** If you belong to him, Jesus is interceding for you right now (Rom. 8:34; Heb. 7:25). Bring him one specific need with confidence.

6 **Memorize John 11:25–26.** "I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live, and everyone who lives and believes in me shall never die."

**Before Lesson 23:** *Read Acts 1–4 and 9–10. Lesson 23 opens Unit 6: the Spirit comes and the church is born.*

## For Discussion

1. Imagine the disciples' Saturday. What did they think had happened to all their hopes?
2. Why does it matter that women were the first witnesses to the empty tomb?
3. Jesus ate fish and showed his scars. Why does it matter that his resurrection body was a real, physical body?
4. Paul says if Christ has not been raised, our faith is futile. Why is the resurrection so central?
5. Paul says Jesus was "raised for our justification." What does his resurrection tell you about whether God accepted his payment for sin?
6. Jesus restored Peter after his denial. What does that say to someone who has failed Jesus badly?
7. The disciples returned from the ascension "with great joy." Why would Jesus leaving make them joyful?
8. Jesus asked Martha, "Do you believe this?" How would you answer him today?

## Sources & For Further Study

- On the historical evidence for the resurrection: N. T. Wright, *The Resurrection of the Son of God*; Gary R. Habermas and Michael R. Licona, *The Case for the Resurrection of Jesus*.
- On the ascension and Christ's present work: Westminster Shorter Catechism 28; Gerrit Scott Dawson, *Jesus Ascended*.
- For further reading: Richard B. Gaffin Jr., *Resurrection and Redemption*; Timothy Keller, *Hope in Times of Fear*.




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